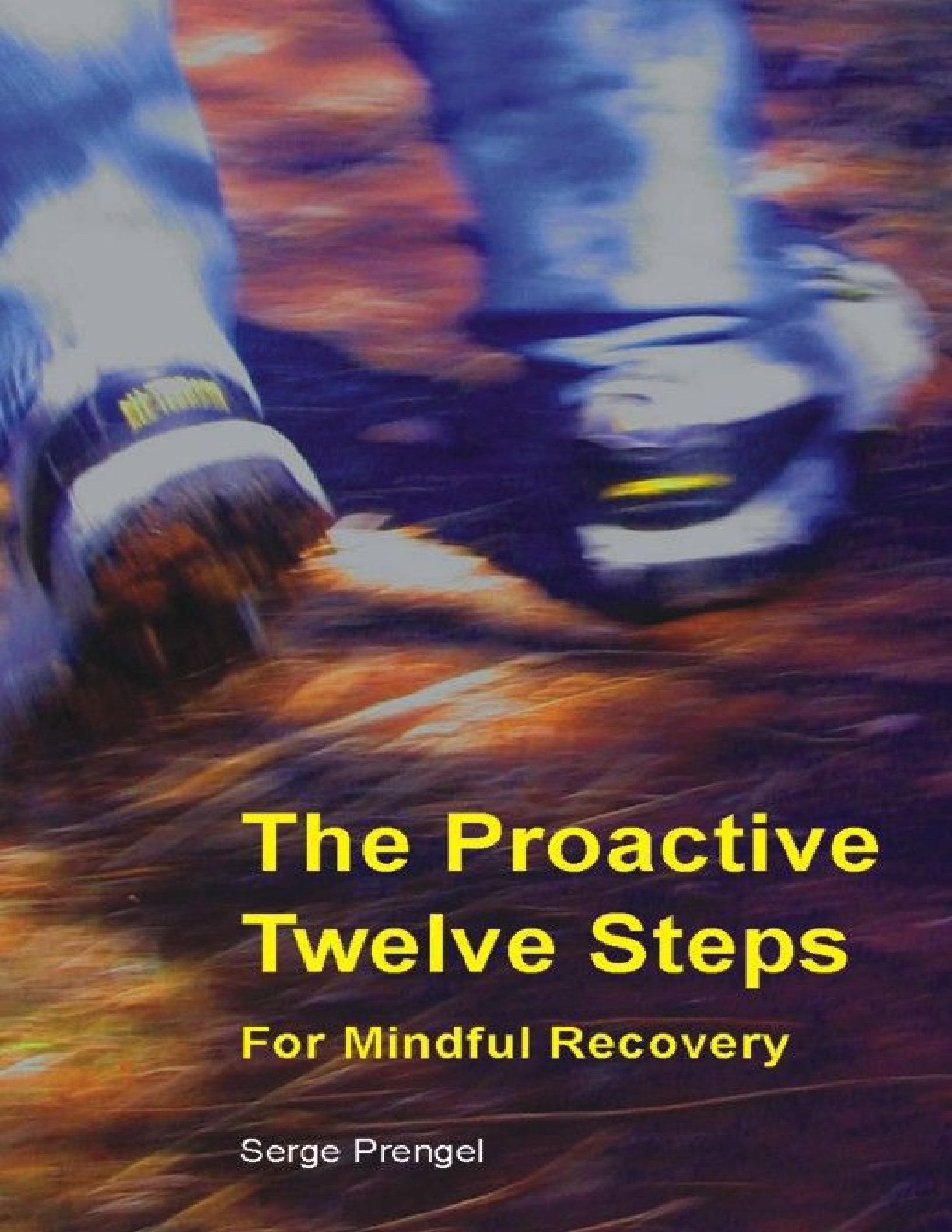


The Proactive Twelve Steps

For Mindful Recovery

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For Mindful Recovery

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Introduction:

Personally and professionally, I am interested in how we make changes in our lives. So I have long been interested in the Twelve Steps.

Millions of people credit the “steps” for their recovery from addiction to alcohol and other substances. I do not have personal or professional experience in this area. So, you may wonder, how are these steps relevant to what I do?

The original Twelve Steps were written by the people who started Alcoholics Anonymous. However, only the first step of A.A. says something about the struggle with alcohol. The other steps provide a framework to, essentially, "get a life".

There is a logic to this: A key insight of A.A. is that the best way to lastingly abandon destructive habits is to have something better to look forward to. This is why the Twelve Steps describe a path toward self-discovery and personal growth.

I believe that, as we develop a deeper sense of who we truly are, we increase our ability to lead a more fulfilling life. This, in turn, makes it easier to make difficult changes.

In this book, you will find the traditional wording of the 12 steps together with an original approach: the "Proactive Twelve Steps".

With this new wording, and the accompanying commentary, my goal is to describe the “steps” as a self-directed process—as opposed to a mystical process in which change somehow happens to you. This is about how you can take a proactive role in your growth as a person.

I originally wrote these steps for people who, like me, were not part of the “Twelve Steps” culture. Over time, many people involved in 12 steps recovery have told me that they find inspiration in these “proactive steps”: Not necessarily as a replacement for the words they are so familiar with, but as a way to gain a new perspective on them.

In any case, I am inviting you to see the “proactive steps” as an invitation to a dialogue, as opposed to a directive that is carved in stone.

Let yourself explore what comes up for you as you go through the steps. Then take the time to digest each step before moving on to the next.

Step One

I get it: What I've been doing is self-destructive. I need to change.

Original wording (AA):

We admitted we were powerless over alcohol—that our lives had become unmanageable.

Codependency:

We admitted we were powerless over others - that our lives had become unmanageable.

Generic version:

We admitted we were powerless over things we believed we should control -- that our lives had become unmanageable.

Discussion of Step 1

Denial

"It's no big deal" or "I don't really have a problem" or "I can handle it" or "I could stop anytime I want" or…

There are many forms of denial. What happens, essentially, is that you don't see what is now blindingly obvious to everybody else: That you have a problem, that things are not working out, that things are out of control.

Why have you been in denial? Well, you didn't invent denial. It is a mechanism that is in all of us. It is a coping mechanism that allows us to function under extremely difficult circumstances.

For instance: We are all mortal. It is an inescapable truth that we are all eventually going to die. It is sad and scary. But, if we kept thinking about our death every moment of our existence, and feeling sad and scared about that, what kind of life would we have?

So denial, in and of itself, is not bad. It can be a very useful mechanism that helps us disengage from problems we cannot solve, and focus on living in the moment.

So, you ask: *How do I know when it's good for me to be in denial, and when it's not?* The test is how it affects your life. If it prevents you from facing realities you could actually deal with, if it prevents you from taking action you could actually take, then it is not good for you.

In this way, the discussion of Step One introduces us to a major theme of this book: The process of proactive personal development is a learning process. We don't just assume we know it all, we don't just take it for granted that somebody else has all the answers. We get information, we experiment (with caution), and we learn by trial and error. This is the meaning of the *quest for serenity, courage and wisdom* (a.k.a. "the Serenity Prayer").

Overwhelm

It's important to keep in mind that denial is a powerful protective strategy that has deep biological foundations. There is a mechanism in our nervous system that is triggered when we are faced with insurmountable problems—very much the way it works on animals in the wild.

When animals are faced with a threat, they have two basic strategies: Either fight, or escape (flight). Neither is inherently good, or bad. For instance, if you're an antelope and you're being hunted by a lion, it really makes no sense to show some resolve and fight! You better run.

When the threat is overwhelming, the animal's nervous system simply can't handle it. *It just doesn't compute.* This is the "deer in the headlights" phenomenon: The deer is paralyzed.

Denial, in this case, is not useful. It is not allowing the animal to go on happily with its life. It would be much more effective to take action (in the case of the deer in the headlights, to run away). But it can't, because its nervous system is in short-circuit mode.

So, think of denial as some sort of a sort of short-circuit mechanism that gets triggered when there is an overwhelming threat. When the animal is that "short-circuit" freeze mode, it cannot override the freeze.

What we're encountering here is another strand that will be pursued throughout this book—the role of fear. Once you're in the grip of fear, your nervous system has its own logic, so to speak. It's the logic of fear, the logic of panic, which has nothing to do with the outlook on the world you have when you feel safe.

Feeling safe

The key part of the journey that is outlined in this book is to find safety. Without safety, it's going to be very difficult to give up your old habits. They are ways of coping that you have developed over time.

"Coping" is too mild a word. To your nervous system, the old habits feel like time-tested protections. They may not work well, but they are the only protections you know, and you would feel unbearably vulnerable without them. Imagine a baby crying as an unfeeling adult tries to pull away his safety blanket… and multiply that baby's fear exponentially: This is the terror of having to live without the protections you have grown accustomed to in the

course of a lifetime.

The healing process of the Proactive Twelve Steps works by building a very real sense of safety. From that solid, really safe place, it will be possible to replace old “protections” that don’t really work, with new ones that work.

A new beginning

Somebody once said: If the only tool you have is a hammer, you try to solve everything by hammering. Well, if the hammer is not solving the problem, it may very well be time to try something else.

The problem is, you may feel that the hammer really should be working… that it will actually work if you just try a little longer…

There’s nothing wrong with persistence. But Step One introduces another consideration: Accountability.

It’s not enough to just say: *I believe it will work one day if I just keep trying*. You need to set goals and deadlines. Not for the sake of putting pressure on yourself… but in order to face the reality of what is happening.

Step One is about looking squarely at reality. If what you’re doing is not working, you acknowledge that. When you do, you are left with a feeling of emptiness – you don’t know what to do, or even whether there is a solution. It can be really scary. However, it is this emptiness that allows you to make room for new, unexpected ideas.

The spirit of the first step

The first step is about facing the reality of your situation. It makes no sense to keep trying to solve problems with "solutions" that can't work. Whenever you realize this, throughout the process, you need to look for a different approach.

In other words, the first step is not just the beginning of this process. It is an attitude. It is about staying grounded in reality as you keep track of your progress.

Stop self-destructive behaviors

Before moving from Step One to what the other eleven steps say, I believe it is important to talk about *what they will not say.*

In Step One, you have the stark realization that you have been in denial: You have a very real problem that you simply can't ignore, and what you've been doing about it has essentially been making things worse.

You might then expect that the following steps would be very sharply worded injunctions to stop your self-destructive behaviors, as well as specific, step-by-step instructions on how to do it.

Instead, in the original Twelve Steps of A.A., only Step One refers to the self-destructive behavior (e.g. alcohol, gambling, codependency)—but then none of the following eleven steps ever does any more. In these Proactive Twelve Steps, while Step Two refers to self-destructive behaviors, the only purpose of this reference is to explain how the healing process works.

Why is that? Clearly, it is not that it has suddenly become OK again to go into denial and to keep behaving the way you were. It is assumed, at this point, that you're realizing the absurdity of clinging to behaviors that are self-destructive. *You need to stop, there is no question about that.*

But this is not a reason to say this eleven more times. Step One very clearly states that *what you've been doing is self-destructive.* Whenever you forget this, please go back to Step One.

Name the specific problem

The only reasons the specific problem behaviors (e.g. drinking, codependency, etc) aren't mentioned in Step One of The Proactive Twelve Steps are practical. As we have seen above, the same steps apply to all these behaviors. Also, there is often more than just one problem behavior—for instance, somebody who abuses alcohol may very well also be codependent in relationships.

It's not enough for you to just say: *I tend to be self-destructive*. The opposite of denial is facing squarely the problem. It is important that you name the specific behavior(s)—e.g. *My codependency in relationships is self-destructive*, or *My overeating is self-destructive*, or *My gambling is self-destructive.…* Please try it, and see what it feels like. If you're not comfortable with it, if it makes you squirm to name the specific problem(s), you're probably still in denial. Which means, it is still so painful for you to face it that you go to great lengths to avoid facing it.

Will these Steps work for me?

Just as the original Twelve Steps, the Steps described in this book are not focused on the problems that got you in trouble in the first place, but on creating a path toward a better life. In other words: The Twelve Steps are a step-by-step description of a broad-scale process of personal growth. They do not tell you how to deal with problem behaviors moment by moment. Hence the two comments that follow.

Proactive personal growth

Self-knowledge is helpful when you want to make changes in your life. The "Proactive Twelve Steps" will help you gain self knowledge. This, in turn, will help you make the changes you want.

But lasting changes will only happen to the extent that you make this an active process. You won't change the way you live by just reading a book and nodding in agreement at the smart things it says.

Keep track of what's happening. Periodically ask yourself whether you are making progress. This means that you need to give some thought to how you will define and evaluate progress.

Take a moment *now* to ask yourself: As I look back, say a month from now, what is it that would make me feel I have made progress? What about a week from today? Three months from today? A year from today? Make sure that these benchmarks include real, observable, changes in behavior.

Being proactive means *looking back from the future*, and *doing what it takes to make the future you want come true*.

Getting the support you need

When people say that the Twelve Steps have helped them, they usually do not mean that they have just been reading a book about the steps. They credit Twelve Steps *meetings* and the *peer support* they provide. It is important that you find support: e.g. friends, a peer group, a support group.

Please keep in mind that peer support may very well not be enough. For one thing, the Steps say nothing about what specifically you do to change your problem behaviors. If you see no change happening, you need to find appropriate help.

This is especially true if you're dealing with addiction. If your habits are endangering yourself or others, you need to see a qualified professional or go to a rehab program.

Please take a moment *now* to ask yourself where you're going to look for support.

Step Two

I see the big picture: The way to stop relapsing into self-destructive behaviors is to build a healthier sense of self.

Original wording (AA):
Came to believe that a power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.

Discussion of Step 2

The original wording of Step Two is about believing in a *power greater than ourselves (that) could restore us to sanity*. This doesn't sound very active, or proactive, does it? Well, I'd like to show you how, once we dispel the obscurity of the original wording, there is actually a very proactive attitude underneath.

A key insight of the Twelve Steps process is that making a major change in your life is *not just* a matter of saying no to bad habits. There's a proactive logic to this: *The best way to lastingly break destructive habits is to have something better to look forward to.*

The purpose of the Steps is to outline the process of changing your life as a whole, in the hope that, in the long run, this will help you stay on the right track. A key part of this process is keeping your eye on the big picture, as opposed to obsessing about the specific habits you want to change.

As you let go of obsessively micro-managing your behaviors, as you allow yourself to look at the big picture, you start to feel the pull of moving forward toward real, meaningful change. So, this *power greater than ourselves* is the power of motivation that comes from looking forward toward the big picture.

Step Two is about letting go of useless "solutions" that seem like they *should* work, despite the fact that they haven't worked for you. This doesn't mean that you are passive, far from that. You are focusing on what you can control. You are taking active steps to change your life. You make room to try new solutions that might work by letting go of what's not working.

As you do so, you are also progressively letting go of the old, narrow sense of who you are (even though you somehow believe it should work).

A radical shift

The above may seem obvious when you read it casually. However, it represents a major shift. It is a radical way to break the vicious cycle which keeps you prisoner of self-destructive behaviors.

Whatever your self-destructive behaviors, you're not feeling very good about them. Chances are that, underneath the denial, there is a lot of guilt and shame. This is actually a big reason for the denial itself: The guilt and shame are so unbearable that the short-circuit mechanism we talked about in Step One turns off conscious awareness.

What are the sources of this guilt and shame? It may have to do with the sense that you're doing something that is socially frowned upon (e.g. excessive gambling or drinking). But, whether or not you feel guilty in regard to society's norms, there is a deeper source of guilt and shame—what you feel in regard to yourself. It comes from a sense of your own weakness, your inability to stand up for yourself: Either standing up for yourself in relationships, as in codependency; or standing up to your own impulses, as in addictions. Hence the need to build a stronger sense of self.

Breaking the vicious cycle

The problem of this opposition between *strong* and *weak* is that it fosters an all-or-nothing mode: The sense that there are only two ways to deal with your self-destructive behavior, either to eradicate it (strong but harsh), or close your eyes to it (weak, in denial). I describe a similar cycle, and the way out of it, in another book: *Self-leadership: Self-motivation, when Just Do It won't do it*. I will give you the gist of it here.

Imagine a dialogue between two parts within yourself. One part is the weak part that has bad habits. And another part is the strong part that wants to change.

Strong tells *Weak*: *You're really bad, This has got to stop. Don't do this any more!*

Weak is intimidated, and, for a while, tries to follow *Strong*'s orders. But *Weak*'s experience is that of being bullied into giving up something very important, with no regard for how it feels to do so. To *Weak*, it feels like it's all about *Strong*'s view of what's important. And so, consciously or not, rebelliously or not, *Weak* reasserts itself by creeping back into the old behaviors.

This, in turn, makes *Strong* more exasperated, harsher. Which, in turn, pushes *Weak* into more of a corner, feeling more deprived.

The radical change, the breakthrough, is to shift away from this dynamic of pressure and deprivation. It is to involve *Weak* into an emotional negotiation. *Strong* now says to *Weak*: *We're in it together. You count. I understand that I cannot ask you to give up what's important to you without giving you something at least as important—in fact,*

something that you'll like even better in the long run.

This is a major shift. In the old pattern, *Strong* felt that the end justified the means, and felt entitled to bully *Weak*. In this new paradigm, *Weak* is treated with respect—which does not mean being indulged. Please also note that we're not talking about manipulation, or bribes. We're talking about genuine satisfaction of real needs. Most importantly, the needs of both parts are respectfully taken into account. This is the fundamental building block of a healthier sense of self.

This may very well feel daunting—no wonder many people feel it can only be accomplished by *a power greater than ourselves*. It is very challenging, indeed. But it can be done, especially as you have a clearer picture of what it is you're attempting to do.

Higher Power & Inner Power

The Proactive Twelve Steps are written without any reference to God or a Higher Power. In contrast, the original wording of Step Two refers to *a power greater than ourselves*. And the original wording of Step Three refers to *God* or a *Higher Power*. Why remove any mention of God or a Higher Power in these Proactive Steps?

One reason is that a secular approach is more likely to be understood by people who are not accustomed to turning to God or a Higher Power. If this were the only reason, it would be a very weak one. These Proactive Twelve Steps would only be some kind of a "lite" version of the "real" steps, and they would only be relevant to those people who "can't stomach the real thing".

What I have found in rewriting the steps is that eliminating the faith element (faith in God or a Higher Power) forced me to pay more attention to describing what actually happens in the process of personal growth (or, at least, my view of it). I alluded to this in the introduction to this book. As we are further along in the process, this is a good time to go further.

The essence of the Twelve Steps approach is to take our focus away from a specific problem that seems unmanageable, and to bring it to another dimension. This powerful shift is like the "jump into hyperspace" in science-fiction movies.

In traditional Twelve Steps wording, this "other dimension" is described as "letting God" (or a Higher Power) guide you. In the Proactive Twelve Steps, the "other dimension" consists in connecting with a larger sense of who you are. This is not meant to alienate people who see God or Higher Power as a key part of the process, as will also be explained below.

The process I describe is one of letting go of dysfunctional habits and ways of thinking, and progressively focusing on the more positive forces within ourselves.

In this process, there is still a leap of faith. It is faith in the basic resiliency of human nature (an assumption that is supported by contemporary neuroscience). All you have to do is think of our basic goodness as a working hypothesis, and be willing to test this hypothesis. Try it, and see if it works for you.

While this approach requires no religious belief, you are of course free to think of this "basic goodness" in divine or religious terms.

If you are religious, I believe you will find these down-to-earth steps a very useful perspective, just the way as a down-to-earth description of the world need not negate, and will often enrich, a religious outlook.

In fact, there can be a convergence of views. The process I describe is one in which you progressively experience a sense of feeling that you are more than your little ego. This experience is what gives you the strength to overcome the dysfunctional habits and be pulled toward fulfilling your life-affirming needs.

This experience can be described as feeling one's *Inner Power*... but it could also be described as feeling one's *Higher Power*. All it takes is thinking of *Higher Power* as a state that we experience, as opposed to a being that is outside of ourselves.

Step Three

I have an action plan: From now on, I am squarely facing everything that is in the way of feeling really satisfied with my life.

Original wording (AA):
Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of our Higher Power as we understood this Higher Power.

Discussion of Step 3

The third Step is the third big shift: After that, the other steps describe the unfolding of the process which has been put in place by then. The shifts are as follows: Step One (*I get it*) is the *insight* that allows you to step out of denial. Step Two is the *strategy* (the *big picture*) that is going to make it possible to do something about this insight. And Step Three is the *action plan* that defines how this strategy can be implemented.

The action plan is very practical. We're not talking about cultivating a *sense of self* that is an abstraction. There is a direct correlation between feeling really satisfied with your life, and this healthier sense of self. In other words: *If you keep finding excuses for not dealing with what makes you profoundly unhappy, you can't really be said to have a very healthy sense of self.* It's that simple. So the action plan is to systematically pay attention to how satisfied you are with your life. If something is not working out, you're going to be dealing with it.

Now, when you just read this casually, this is the kind of thing you're likely to shrug off. *No big deal, it's obvious, isn't it what everybody does anyway?* However, if you start paying more attention to this, you'll see the many ways in which you find excuses to avoid facing your lack of satisfaction in many areas; and how this festers into a sense of powerlessness and lingering resentment. The sense of powerlessness and the resentment, in turn, will "justify" your acting out. And the acting out will feed into your sense of guilt and shame. And so on. This is how you stay trapped in the vicious cycle described in Step Two.

The way out is to make it a clear priority to not accept any excuses to avoid facing what is in the way of your sense of well-being and happiness.

Now, this does not mean that, by confronting these challenges, you will always get what you want. There are plenty of limitations in life. So I am not saying that you will only be truly happy if you get everything you want, no matter what it is you want. The quest for Serenity, Courage & Wisdom (aka "Serenity Prayer") includes finding *the serenity to accept what you cannot change*–once you're satisfied that you truly can't change it, not because you have avoided dealing with it.

Different priorities

Step 3 is about focusing your efforts into increasing your sense of wholeness and contentment in life. Putting the priority on improving your life means that "fixing" the problems is no longer the top priority. Until now, the problems have been on top: Either consciously (because you've actively been trying to solve them with "solutions" that didn't work)… Or unconsciously (because you've been in denial, which means they've been hovering, like a threatening dark cloud, in your subconscious).

This is probably confusing. So I'll give you an analogy. Let's say you have a really high fever. It makes sense to do whatever it takes to lower the fever, because staying with a high fever is not only unpleasant, it can also hurt you. However, it's very important to remember that the fever is just a symptom, and the lasting solution requires that you deal with the underlying problem that caused the fever in the first place.

A leap of faith

What does all of this have to do with the original wording of this Step (*…to turn our will and our lives over to the care of our Higher Power…*)? There is a leap of faith in Step Three (just that it does not have to be a religious one). It is to focus on the *big picture* defined in Step Two. To focus on your sense of wholeness and contentment, you have to stop being so fixated on your problems. As you do this, you may feel that you're being self-indulgent, or even that you don't deserve to be happy. The more stuck you are, the stronger these feelings will be, the more entrenched to need to keep doing what you're already doing even though it doesn't work for you.

Transformation

In Step One, you started to see that self-destructive behaviors have to do with fear. We're talking about intense fears, attempting to deal with stuff that feels overwhelming. What is it, then, that makes change possible, especially in the grip of fear?

As you progressively let go of your fixation on your problems and your usual ways of dealing with them, you notice more how much you had been tightening up—how much you had been wanting to control things—when you

were feeling overwhelmed. Noticing this helps you begin to relax this tension.

You start noticing the knee-jerk quality of your reactions to certain situations–-things happen so fast that you haven't until now realized that there was any possibility of doing anything different. Noticing this, you become more aware that you have a choice of how to react in these situations. Little by little, you discover that your range of reactions is much broader than you were accustomed to. You broaden our sense of who you are. Compared to how you used to be, *it feels like* you have been touched by the presence of something greater than yourself.

Indeed, you have expanded beyond the more limited part of you that you used to think was all of you. As you expand your repertoire in response to what used to overwhelm you, it *feels like* you're in the benevolent hand of a higher power that protects you.

A quest for serenity, courage & wisdom

I seek
the serenity to accept what I cannot change;
the courage to change what I can;
and the wisdom to know the difference.

Original wording (Reinhold Niebuhr):
God, grant me the serenity
to accept the things
I cannot change,
Courage to change the
things I can, and the
wisdom to know the difference.

Discussion of the Quest for Serenity, Courage & Wisdom

The Twelve Steps process can be described as a quest for *effective* power and control. Control is not a dirty word. The problem is when we keep trying to control what we have no business controlling.

So, despite the name it is generally known by ("Serenity Prayer"), this quest is not just about Serenity. It is also about Courage and Wisdom. This quest is not just about learning to let go and learning courage. It is about knowing when to fight for change, and when to learn to live with what is.

In other words, blind acceptance of everything is not a virtue any more than indiscriminate fighting is. There is a time and place for each. Wisdom is not something that is magically, suddenly imparted on us. It is a process. We acquire wisdom by making decisions. Some of them work out well; some don't. We learn through trial and error.

This is a mindful process, through which we grow not only our wisdom, but also our ability to be mindful—which, in turn, helps us grow in wisdom. In other words, this is the opposite of a vicious cycle—a virtuous cycle, so to speak. A very important part of this process is granting ourselves the permission to make the mistakes through which we may learn.

Step Four

I honestly look at the effects of my actions on others and myself.

Original wording (AA):
Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.

Discussion of Step 4

Honesty

When things aren't working well, the temptation is to hunker down, feel defensive, and try to prove why what you're doing should work. Of course, this won't make things work.

Step 4 is about stepping away from the heat of battle, and taking a non-partisan look at your own actions.

Does it mean that you were bad, and you now have to become good? No, you're certainly not trying to become an angel (or to convince yourself that you're one). In fact, if you try to go that route, your life somehow becomes even more unmanageable.

All you have to do is try to not be so defensive. That is, try to just face the reality of what you do without jumping to justify it in the same breath.

The original Twelve Steps called Step 4 a "fearless" moral inventory. The fearlessness lies in that you accept to face reality, whatever it is.

Beyond good and evil

What makes this kind of honesty possible is removing the notion of judgment -- that is, the potential for blame and shame. Step Four is about looking at facts -- as opposed to adding overlays of judgment and blame onto them in such a way that the facts become obscured.

There is a big difference between being in Criminal Court and doing Step 4:

- In Criminal Court, the rule is for the indicted person to avoid responsibility.
- In Step 4, your goal is to work toward taking responsibility for what you do.

Why would you do that? It is a logical continuation of the leap of faith described earlier. Your hope is that, *whatever you find out about yourself, it will be something that you can live with*.

This will lead you to eventually get to know your true self. And that this true you might turn out to be a better person than you thought you were!

Step Five

I take responsibility for my actions.

Original wording (AA):
Admitted to our Higher Power, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.

Discussion of Step 5

No excuses

Step Five is not about saying: "I hurt these people, but that was because they had hurt me first".

Blaming somebody else -- no matter how richly they deserve it -- is a way of not fully feeling these feelings of hurt and anger, of toning them down. Because, when you blame others, you are putting your attention on what others are doing. In effect, you are saying: "If it weren't for what you did, it wouldn't have happened."

This step is about admitting to yourself what may be difficult for you to admit.

Admit it!

If you think you're being coerced into "taking responsibility", the image that comes to mind is that of the stern interrogator -- the cop who's badgering the suspect to confess: "Admit your wrongs!"

In such a context, you will tend to see things as a battle of wills against the tough cop. Your goal will then be to avoid admitting anything incriminating.

Step Five is different from that.

Taking responsibility for what you do is a way to realize that you are an *active agent* in the world. In other words, you are *not powerless*, even if you are not yet aware of the ways in which your power manifests, or if you don't like these ways.

As you get more of a sense of your power, you will be able to redirect it to focus on getting more of what you really want out of life.

Step Six

I see that my knee-jerk reactions have to do with being in the grip of more or less conscious fears.

Original wording (AA):
Were entirely ready to have our Higher Power remove all these defects of character.

Discussion of Step 6

Character defenses

We all have character defenses, a whole range of them. Some are pretty innocuous, and some are more problematic. Our character defenses are what provides the material of comedy.

For instance, take a greedy person. You could say greed is a major defect. On the other hand, being greedy can also be seen as a defense against the fear of starvation, of not having enough to live on.

What's a character defense? Something we are accustomed to doing automatically, in order to consciously or unconsciously avoid dealing with something difficult.

Talking about "defense" does not condone the questionable behavior. It just makes it more understandable why people hang on to these behaviors.

You don't use your character defenses because you want to be laughed at. Or because you revel in being evil. Somehow, at some level, you believe this behavior is a protection against something that you fear a lot.

Becoming more aware of your fears

If you pay attention, you'll notice that you go into a defense behavior when you feel threatened. So, when you are in a very stressful situation, you'll tend to fall back onto your defenses a lot more than usual.

Step 6 is about getting ready to let go of your character defenses. Which means realizing how much more important they are to you than you had thought. After all, if they weren't, it wouldn't be such a big thing to change!

So you decide to explore your fears in order to eventually be less governed by your fears and your defensiveness… in order to be more willing to go with the flow instead of automatically resisting.

Step Seven

I strive to find my motivation in a deeper sense of who I really am, rather than fear and defensiveness.

Original wording (AA):
Humbly asked our Higher Power to remove our shortcomings.

Discussion of Step 7

The power of choice

In Step Six, you noticed how character defenses take over as your “default mode” under difficult circumstances. Before, it felt like you had no choice over what you did. Now, as you’re becoming more aware of what is behind your actions, you gain the possibility of making different choices.

The hope is that, as you get more of a sense of wholeness and contentment in your life, the choices you make will be less and less influenced by your fears and the knee-jerk reactions they induce.

A humbling realization

It is humbling to realize that you have conflicting motivations, and that the most powerful ones are not necessarily the ones you'd be proudest of.

Little by little, you learn that lasting transformation doesn't come through sheer force of will and impatient proddings. Rather, it is the result of slowly observing your inner conflicts and fears, and progressively shifting from fear-based reactions to ones grounded in a deeper, safer sense of self.

As you go through this process, you develop a sense of awe -- something that is akin to what religious people may describe as a prayer, in the sense that praying is about being open and vulnerable, rather than about placing an order.

A sense of awe

This is a time when you realize how much you want something to happen, at the very time as you are fully aware that it is beyond your conscious control to have it happen when you want it, the way you want it.

There is a lot of tension in that. You can resolve this tension by pretending you can control things, by having a temper tantrum... or by humbly accepting your lack of control over something that is very important to you.

In a way, you're back at Step One -- admitting your powerlessness, your lack of control over things you'd so much want to be able to control.

You let yourself want what you want, even though it's not a sure thing, even though there's a big risk of disappointment. This is quite different from, either deluding yourself that you can control the outcome; or pretending to yourself that you don't really want the result, just because you can't bear to want something that you have no control over.

When you make an effort to be conscious of the impulses behind your actions, and of the choices you have, you are engaged in a spiritual process. You are deeply aware of your human limitations, and at the same time you are connecting with a broader sense of self that helps you go beyond these limitations.

Step Eight

I stop blaming and feeling blamed, with a willingness to heal the wounds.

Original wording (AA):
Made a list of all the people we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.

Discussion of Step 8

Pleasure in Revenge

There is great satisfaction in getting revenge for what others did to you. If you can hurt them, in turn, at least you'll stop being a punching bag, you'll show them!

It's understandable that there are people you'd love to hurt even more than you've done so far.

Step 8 is about realizing how much revenge and blame are ingrained in all of us... and starting to walk away from these tendencies.

A different focus

Why is that? As long as you keep blaming others (or feeling susceptible to blame), you cast yourself in the role of a powerless victim. You say you have no power over your actions. You pretend you're such a powerless puppet that even the harmful things you do are other people's responsibility!

You're following these Proactive Twelve Steps to regain power over the things you can have power over. You may not have much power over other people... but you certainly have some power over the way you behave.

If you acknowledge that there is some pleasure in your harming other people, that it is your way of feeling less powerless... then you're no longer stuck on the defensive. You now have a choice between continuing to do the same thing, or moving on.

At some point, you may decide that, while there is some pleasure in revenge, it's not really what you want most out of life… that you'd rather focus on being happy.

Step Nine

I swallow my pride, and sincerely apologize to people I've hurt, except when this would be counterproductive.

Original wording (AA):
Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.

Discussion of Step 9

Actual apologies

There's a difference between Step Eight and Step Nine. It lies in the fact that Step Nine is about actually apologizing.

Instead of being essentially in a conversation with yourself, you are now facing another person. A person you have hurt, and who is probably not favorably disposed toward you.

There is the possibility that this person just doesn't get it, is still very resentful, makes fun of your attempts... Just the thought of it makes it harder to apologize.

It's tempting to think: "What really counts is that I resolved things inside. I figured out what I've done wrong, I've become ready and willing to make apologies.

So why bother actually confronting another person, and submit myself to reactions that are beyond my control?"

The freedom of new beginnings

A big change happens, inside you, after you genuinely apologize to somebody you've hurt.

Before you apologize: You can't tell people you are sorry because you feel it would mean admitting you're wrong -- this threatens your position in an unbearable way.

After you apologize: You now see that you can *still exist and feel safe* in a world in which you have taken the risk of feeling sorry for something you did.

This is what this whole process is about.

When is it appropriate?

It may be quite difficult to figure out when it is appropriate to rock the boat, and when it is inappropriately hurtful to others.

This is OK: Welcome to the real world, where choices are not necessarily simple. This is very much the essence of the growth process exemplified by the *Quest for Serenity, Courage & Wisdom* ("Serenity Prayer"). You want to acquire the wisdom to know the difference between when to accept things and when to fight for change. You acquire this wisdom through trial and error.

It's useful to think of this step as a guiding principle, as opposed to a recipe that you must follow blindly. There's no guarantee you'll be absolutely right, beyond reproach, if you follow this step. Instead, you have to figure out how it applies to your situation. This engages your conscious attention and helps you learn.

You may be making a mistake in making apologies to people you shouldn't. On the other hand, you may be erring by being too cautious... So, you experiment.

Here's one way to look at it. If apologizing is a way to make you feel smug and superior (like playing a game of "I'm a better person than you"), then it's probably not appropriate. Conversely, it is appropriate when it is a way to build a bridge to the other person, to feel closer.

Step Ten

I live mindfully, paying attention to the motives and effects of my actions.

Original wording (AA):
Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.

Discussion of Step 10

An inner moral compass

Step Ten means staying conscious, aware of what you do in your life. Conscious, aware… as opposed to living in a cloud of denial. Taking responsibility for your actions.

"Doing the right thing" does not mean doing just what takes you out of a tight spot. When you "do the right thing", you get a sense that what you're doing is in harmony with the world.

This is not a watertight definition of "doing the right thing" -- it has a lot of holes. But there is some merit to this lack of precision: This process is about getting an intuitive feel what's right, an inner moral compass.

Suppose you're getting angry at somebody and laying a lot of blame on them at a time when you can get away with it. It may feel good at the moment -- it lets you get off steam. But it certainly isn't something that makes you feel in touch with your higher self, or especially proud of yourself.

Step Ten is the compass that has you ask: *Did this move help me move toward where I want to go?* Or, to put it into a more colorful way: *How can you expect to soar with eagles if you keep behaving like a turkey?*

Ultimately, Step Ten is about keeping in mind who you are and what you want out of life. When you admit you've been wrong, you're not in a childlike role -- the bad little kid who gets punished for being wrong. You are a conscious adult who is able to notice where you went off course, and you are putting yourself back on the right track.

This is a good time to revisit earlier steps, about being defensive, about shoulds... This is a process. You have to keep working at it, because your habits are solidly ingrained. Going through this process is not a one-time thing that you do, and then it's over.

This process is about learning a different way of facing the challenges of life. As your life goes on, you'll keep facing the realities of what you do and who you are, and how you want to deal with happens along the way.

Step Eleven

I stay in touch with a broader sense of who I really am, and a deeper sense of what I really want.

Original wording (AA):

Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with our Higher Power as we understood this Higher Power, praying only for knowledge of this Higher Power's will for us and the power to carry that out.

Discussion of Step 11

What is implicit in this step -- as in the whole Proactive Twelve Steps approach -- is that you can find a lot of the answers within yourself. All you have to do is calm the fears that prevent you from connecting with what is good within yourself -- whether you call it God, a Higher Power, or anything else.

A contemplative attitude

By now, you have a good sense of the process of the Proactive Twelve Steps: Lasting changes don't happen from being forced through sheer power of will. Instead, you take the time to pay attention.

An analogy to this process is how to deal effectively with a tangled cord. If you focus on making something happen fast, you pull and pull. The more you pull, the tighter the knots, the harder to untangle the cord. If, instead, you focus on loosening the cord, it eventually becomes much easier to disentangle.

Going through this process, you have been practicing a contemplative, meditative attitude. As you live your everyday life, as you face the challenges of life, big and small, you *stay tuned inside, in touch with a broader sense of who you really are, and a deeper sense of what you really want.*

Of course, you can also look for a formal meditation practice, as the original wording of the step calls for. There's nothing wrong with that. Meditation is a good way to be in conscious contact with your True Nature, your Life Force, your own inherent goodness. You can experiment with various forms of meditation -- some techniques may work better for you than others. But the point is *not* to add yet another activity (this one, called meditation) to the long list of things you have to do in your day (e.g. *brush teeth, then meditate, then…).* The point is to integrate the kind of proactive contemplation I have been describing into your normal, everyday life.

A sense of spaciousness

Similarly, as we have seen in Step Seven, organized religions do not have a monopoly on prayer, in the sense that prayer is not a magical way of "placing an order" for what you want. Prayer is what happens when you realize how much you want something, and how little control you have over what happens.

In fact, some people's religious practices and rituals can sometimes be a way to delude themselves about having control when they actually don't. Take, for instance, the ritual of doing a "rain dance": If you see the rain dance as a way of expressing how fervently you want the rain, and how little control you have over whether it actually rains, you are very much in tune with the limitations of the human condition. On the other hand, if you feel that, by doing the rain dance, you are actually activating a mechanism that will make rain happen, you're out of touch with reality.

So, throughout this process, we have been cultivating an ability to find a sense of peace, a sense of spaciousness, in the midst of tensions and problems. It's the opposite of feeling agitation, of rushing around. The opposite of feeling "I can't bear this". You develop your intuitive sense of your authentic self. In other words: You are more comfortable in your skin.

Step Twelve

A growing sense of wholeness and contentment motivates me to keep at it, and to reach out to others who are struggling.

Original wording (AA):
Having had a spiritual awakening as a result of these Steps, we tried to carry this message to other (alcoholics, codependents, people who feel stuck...); and to practice these principles in all our affairs.

Discussion of Step 12

A journey of transformation

Joseph Campbell analyzed myths throughout a multitude of cultures in human history. He found striking similarities among them. He pointed out that the "hero journey" of myth is symbolic of the process of personal growth.

The Twelve Steps are a great tool for your own "hero journey", the process of becoming who you really are.

The journey starts with the realization of your lack of power: *You have a very real problem; and your ways of dealing with it aren't working*. As you're no longer in denial about this lack of power, you embark on a quest. By the twelfth step, you are *more keenly aware of how what you do affects your experience of life*.

In other words, you have become more aware of how and where you have control. You're shifting your focus to what you can control to actually make things happen instead of banging your head against a wall.

You see the world with different eyes, you experience the world in a different way. It is as if you had been transported into a different world.

Awakening

In the original wording of the step, the sense that a powerful transformation has been happening is conveyed by the phrase "spiritual awakening".

It is as if you had been asleep until such a time as you have this awakening. When you're asleep, you may not notice what's happening around you. But you certainly notice the alarm clock that's waking you up.

The world outside hasn't change. What has changed is the way you experience it. From feeling powerless and victimized, you now feel more at peace with the world. This is a different perspective, a much broader one.

There are still many things you'll feel powerless about. But you have less of a tendency to take the things you are powerless about as a personal insult. You tend to get less mired into what frustrates you. And you direct more of your energy in directions where you have some power to get what you want. You feel better about yourself.

Staying on course

Implicit in the idea of feeling better about yourself is the notion that this will motivate you to stay on course.

Let's say you start a program of physical exercise "to get fit". You won't stay fit unless you keep exercising. And chances are you'll keep exercising if you actually enjoy the exercising itself, as opposed to feeling it's something you have to do only as a means to an end.

This process is not about acquiring anything, other than habits. It's about practicing these habits, one day at a time.

Reaching out

You reach out to others out of altruism... but there is a benefit to yourself as well. Sharing your experience is not about dealing with others from a one-up position ("I know all the answers, and I have to educate others who are less fortunate than I am"). It makes you feel more connected when you to associate with other people who experience similar problems.

The Proactive Twelve Steps

Step 1:
I get it: What I've been doing is self-destructive. I need to change.
Step 2:
I see the big picture: The way to stop relapsing into self-destructive behaviors is to build a healthier sense of self.
Step 3:
I have an action plan: From now on, I am squarely facing everything that is in the way of feeling really satisfied with my life.
Step 4:
I honestly look at the effects of my actions on others and myself.
Step 5:
I take responsibility for my actions.
Step 6:
I see that my knee-jerk reactions have to do with being in the grip of more or less conscious fears.
Step 7:
I strive to find my motivation in a deeper sense of who I really am, rather than fear and defensiveness.
Step 8:
I stop blaming and feeling blamed, with a willingness to heal the wounds.
Step 9:
I swallow my pride, and sincerely apologize to people I've hurt, except when this would be counterproductive.
Step 10:
I live mindfully, paying attention to the motives and effects of my actions.
Step 11:
I stay in touch with a broader sense of who I really am, and a deeper sense of what I really want.
Step 12:
A growing sense of wholeness and contentment motivates me to keep at it, and to share this process with others who are struggling.

About

About the author

Serge Prengel helps people make the changes they want, in their life, career and relationships. In person in New York City, or by phone.

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